Cracking Job Interviews

Introduction

A job interview is a structured conversation in which an employer assesses whether a candidate has the skills, knowledge, attitude and personality needed for a job, and the candidate also learns about the job and the company. For freshers, interviews usually follow a written or online aptitude test and sometimes a group discussion, and may include technical rounds, an HR round and a managerial round. Success in interviews comes from preparation, practice, clear communication and confidence. Interviewers look for knowledge of the subject, problem-solving, communication skills, teamwork, honesty, learning attitude and fit with the company's culture.

Types of Interviews

In a technical interview, questions test subject knowledge, coding, projects and problem-solving. The HR interview checks attitude, motivation, strengths, weaknesses and fit. A behavioural interview asks about past situations to predict future behaviour. A group discussion tests communication and leadership. A case interview is used in consulting. Panel interviews have several interviewers, and online or video interviews have become common, requiring a stable internet connection, a quiet room, good lighting, and professional dress.

What Is the STAR Method?

The STAR method is a structured way to answer behavioural interview questions, such as "Tell me about a time when you faced a challenge" or "Describe a time you worked in a team". STAR stands for Situation, Task, Action and Result. Situation: describe the context briefly, such as where and when it happened. Task: explain your specific responsibility or goal. Action: describe the steps you took, focusing on what you personally did, using "I" rather than "we". Result: share the outcome, with numbers where possible, and what you learned. For example: "In my final-year project (Situation), our team had to build a plant disease detector in six weeks, and I was responsible for the model training (Task). I collected 2,000 leaf images, used data augmentation and fine-tuned a pre-trained network (Action). The accuracy improved from 78 to 92 percent, and we won the best project award (Result)." The method keeps answers focused and gives evidence of your skills. Prepare four to six STAR stories from your projects, internships, college activities and challenges, covering teamwork, leadership, conflict, failure, and problem-solving, which can be adapted for many questions. A good answer takes about one to two minutes.

How Should You Answer "Tell Me About Yourself"?

This is almost always the first question, and it is not an invitation to read out your resume or tell your life story. It is a chance to make a strong first impression with a short, relevant, confident summary of about one to two minutes. A good structure is Present, Past, Future. Present: start with who you are now: your degree, college and key skills. Past: mention relevant projects, internships, achievements or experiences that have prepared you for the job. Future: end with why you are interested in this role and company and what you hope to achieve. For example: "I am a final-year B.E. Computer Science student from Anna University with a strong interest in data analysis. During my internship I built dashboards in Power BI, and in my final-year project I built a model predicting student dropouts using Python. I enjoy solving problems with data, and I'm excited about this role because it lets me apply these skills to real business problems." Keep it professional: avoid personal details like family and hobbies unless relevant, avoid repeating the resume word by word, do not speak for more than two minutes, and practise until it sounds natural but not memorised.

Other Common Questions

Common questions include "Why do you want to work here?", "What are your strengths and weaknesses?", "Why should we hire you?", "Where do you see yourself in five years?", "Tell me about your project", "What is your biggest achievement?", "Are you willing to relocate?" and "Do you have any questions for us?". For strengths, choose real strengths relevant to the job and give an example. For weaknesses, mention a genuine, non-critical weakness and show what you are doing to improve it. Always prepare questions to ask, such as about training, the team and growth opportunities, and avoid asking about salary or leave in the first round.

Name Three Common Interview Mistakes

Three common interview mistakes are arriving late or unprepared, speaking negatively about others, and giving vague or dishonest answers. Arriving late or without researching the company shows a lack of seriousness; candidates should reach 10 to 15 minutes early and know about the company's products, mission and the job. Speaking badly about previous employers, colleges, teachers or team members suggests poor attitude. Giving vague, rambling or dishonest answers, such as claiming skills that you don't have, will be exposed by follow-up questions. Other mistakes include poor body language, such as slouching, no eye contact or fidgeting; checking the mobile phone; dressing inappropriately; not listening carefully to the question; not knowing your own resume and projects; being overconfident or arrogant; interrupting the interviewer; not asking any questions at the end; and not saying thank you.

Preparation Checklist

Research the company, the role and the interviewers. Revise subject fundamentals and projects thoroughly, practise coding or aptitude, and rehearse answers aloud or with a friend (a mock interview). Carry copies of your resume, certificates, ID and a notebook. Dress neatly and formally, and have a firm handshake and a smile. During the interview, listen carefully, take a moment to think, speak clearly, be honest if you don't know ("I don't know, but here is how I would find out"), maintain eye contact and show enthusiasm. Afterwards, send a short thank-you email within 24 hours.

Interviews in India and Chennai

Campus placement drives by IT companies such as TCS, Infosys, Wipro, HCL, Cognizant and Zoho, and core companies in Chennai's automobile and manufacturing sector, follow a pattern of aptitude test, technical and HR interviews. Zoho is known for coding-based selection. Knowledge of English and the local language, along with professional behaviour, matters.

Challenges and Future

Interview anxiety is normal; deep breathing and practice reduce it. AI-based video interviews and online assessments are becoming common, but communication, honesty and preparation remain the basis for success.

Quick Facts

- The STAR method stands for Situation, Task, Action and Result.
- Answer "Tell me about yourself" in one to two minutes using Present, Past, Future.
- Three common mistakes: arriving late or unprepared, speaking negatively about others, and vague or dishonest answers.
- Reach interviews 10 to 15 minutes early and send a thank-you email within 24 hours.
- Prepare questions to ask the interviewer.